

## ANNA NAGAR

Purasawalkam » Villivakkam » Kolathur » Nazarathpettai » Pattabiram » Maduravoyal » Koyambedu » Tiruverkadu » Puzhal » Kilpauk » Perambur » Mogappair  
Avadi » Ayyappakkam » Tiruninravur » Nerkundram » Moolakadai » Ayanavaram » Retteri » Padi » Ambattur » Tirumullaivoyal » Aminjikarai » Vysarpadi » Red Hills

## 'Approach road to Ambattur railway station is *squalid*'



GNG Road at Varadarajapuram in Ambattur. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

K.V. SAIKRISHNA

Ambattur railway station is being given a facelift under Amrit Bharat Station Scheme. But GNG Road at Varadarajapuram in Ambattur where the station's main entrance is located suffers from poor sanitation due to overflowing garbage bins. The place stinks and is fly

blown. This is a narrow road and witnesses heavy traffic as it provides connectivity to CTH Road, a State Highway. But these bins hinder traffic movement by attracting cattle. Pedestrian safety is also compromised near these bins. Greater Chennai Corporation officials should address this issue promptly.

*K.V. Saikrishna is a resident of Ambattur*



## CHUG DOWN MADRAS OF 1856

The on-going mini train exhibition by Chennai Rail Museum at Integral Coach Factory concludes on May 3. **P3**



## CHENNAI RESIDENTS, TAKE CLEANLINESS SURVEY SERIOUSLY NOW

Animators are reaching out to groups seeking that individuals answer a set of 13 questions **P4**

## You can be our volunteer writer

Dear readers, you can be our volunteer-writer by writing to us about issues and events in your neighbourhood. You should send the write-ups to [downtownfeedback@thehindu.co.in](mailto:downtownfeedback@thehindu.co.in). Letters must carry the contact number



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## ‘Bus stop near Red Hills terminus lacks shelter’



The bus stop near Red Hills bus terminus on GNT Road. The image was taken on April 28, 2026.

T. GUNASEELAN

The section of GNT Road near Red Hills bus terminus is known for congestion and chaos. Vendors and parked vehicles including a line of share-autorickshaws occupy a sizeable road space here.

There is a bus stop opposite the terminus but buses halt wherever space is available. Commuters have to move swiftly and board the buses. Further, this bus stop lacks a shelter and commuters have to brave the elements.

But ever since the renovation work began at the bus terminus last June, the congestion on this stretch of road has worsened.

This terminus is temporarily functioning from a vacant parcel of land that lies on the same road a few kilometres away. However, buses continue to drop and pick up commuters on the section of GNT Road near the original terminus which is helpful and convenient for commuters. But the encroachments on the road make it quite difficult for the MTC drivers.

T. Gunaseelan is a resident of Ambattur

## ‘Pipeline leak on service road in Retteri’



The service road under Retteri flyover on March 11 and April 23 this year. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



HARI SUNDAR PYDA

Most of the days, stagnant water can be found on the service road under Retteri flyover, near Shell petrol bunk.

An underground pipeline leak was found as the source. It is not clear if this is a water or sewage pipeline. Pedestrians find it difficult to use this road; and its soggy state is adding to the problem.

The authorities concerned should address this issue.

Hari Sundar Pyda is a resident of Retteri.



## ‘Villivakkam bus terminus misused as thoroughfare’

M. SENTHIL

Private vehicles misusing the temporary Villivakkam bus terminus on Konnur High Road as a thoroughfare has become a common sight. The terminus is functioning from the premises of ICF which is a lane along Konnur High Road. But motorists in order to avoid waiting at the near-

by junction of Konnur High Road and Ambedkar Road, they drive through the terminus.

All kinds of vehicles including vans, trucks, and cars use the terminus. This compromises safety at the terminus. Metropolitan Transport Corporation is requested to look into this issue.

M. Senthil is a resident of Villivakkam



## ‘Set up a paid parking facility at Vinayagapuram bus terminus’

V. VARIAMUTHU

Regular commuters of Vinayagapuram bus terminus on Perambur-Red Hills Road used to park their motorcycles there. Yes, parking is not permitted at the terminus; and to prevent parking of vehicles, the area was barricaded recently.

I request Metropolitan Transport Corporation to consider setting up an authorised parking lot at the terminus.

In other words, a paid parking facility.

Not many buses are operated from the terminus. Vast space is lying underutilised. It will be quite useful for commuters if they are allowed to park their vehicles there.

V. Variamuthu is a resident of Surapet

The barricaded portion at Vinayagapuram bus terminus. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



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# Chug down the Madras of 1856

The ongoing mini train exhibition by Chennai Rail Museum at Integral Coach Factory concludes on May 3

LIFFY THOMAS

**W**ith the forty mini model and 20 intricate layouts, this mini train exhibition is sure to strike a nostalgia chord in every visitor.

Organised by Chennai Rail Museum at Integral Coach Factory from May 1 to May 3 to celebrate World Heritage Day, a closer look and one can discover the artistry, engineering and cultural significance of Railways across generations.

For the first time, the host is also among the participants. Chennai Rail Museum has showcased a mini rail project of Madras in 1856 donated by Maurice W. Roacha of Brisbane, Queensland in Australia. The Anglo-Indian, a resident of



The train project donated by Maurice W. Roacha from Australia

Chennai before migrating to Australia, is passionate about modelling trains and wanted to gift this to someone when the Museum gladly accepted it.

“In memory and gratitude to The Railway family of the bygone days, who served the Indian Railways with dignity and pride,” reads a note.

The model showcases the Madras Railway Company (MRC) and the city of Madras as its background.

MRC founded in 1845, and after many years of negotiating with the East India Company and the Government of Madras, an agreement was made, to build a railway from Madras Wallajah Road and then to

Arcot with Royapuram as its terminal. A short note along with the model explains how MRC changed hands and became the Madras and Southern Maharashtra Railway and then to Southern Railway.

In its fourth edition now, the mini train exhibition has grown over the years. This time, there are hobbyists from Mumbai, Bengaluru

## What, when and where

**On display:** Thomas train, Vande Bharat, All UNESCO Railways (Nilgiri Mountain Railway Locos, Darjeeling Himalayan Railway Locos, Katra Railway loco), New Pamban Bridge in Movement, Christmas Express and Three Tier Running Tracks

**Venue:** Chennai Rail Museum, New Avadi Road

**Ticket Cost:** ₹15 for children below age 13; ₹40 for adults (The ticket cost includes a toy train ride and gallery visits)

and Cochin as well showcasing their scale models.

This event is not only a tribute to the legacy of trains but also an opportunity to inspire curiosity and appreciation among visitors of all ages. With detailed layouts, interactive displays and passionate exhibitors, the exhibition promises to be both educational and entertaining, says a note. It reflects the enduring role of trains in connecting people, places and histories, while offering a platform for hobbyists and professionals to share their craft.



## Cool Darjeeling comes to hot Chennai

A fascination that started in school has turned into an obsession for T. Senthilkumar

**N**ever mind if you have not been to Darjeeling, check out T. Senthilkumar's scale train models at the exhibition. The associate director with an MNC has tried to recreate the Himalayan town around its railway line. The engine is an exact

replica of the Himalayan Darjeeling Engine which is currently running, he says. There are some 120 small parts that went into making this scale model; it took close to two years for Senthil to source those parts. The Porur resident says this hobby is a bit of a

science, art and self-discovery. “I was fascinated since childhood. I design and build detailed train layouts that combine creativity, engineering and storytelling. Each layout reflects real-world railway operations, including signals, terrain and automated train control. Through my work, I aim to inspire others to explore this fascinating hobby and appreciate the beauty of railways in a scaled-down form,” he says.





# Chennai residents, take cleanliness survey seriously now

With citizen feedback for Swachh Survekshan having begun, animators are reaching out to various groups seeking that individuals answer a set of 13 questions. Chennai is believed to have been doing poorly in this annual assessment partly due to its residents' reluctance to take the survey



Animators request a resident to take part in the survey and (right) outside a textile showroom.

LIFFY THOMAS

If you are stopped by an animator, a professional in Greater Chennai Corporation ranks, and asked to take part in a cleanliness survey of the city then do spare a few minutes for them.

The Citizen Feedback for the 10th edition of Swachh Survekshan is on and every input by a resident slipped into the online system will help determine where Chennai stands among cities in terms of its cleanliness quotient.

The survey is not just about rankings but improving people's quality of life, which makes public participation significant.

Citizen participation is the cornerstone of the initiative, with 35% of the total percentage of marks allotted based on what its people have to say about various initiatives taken by the city corporations. However, over the years, what has put Chennai at a disadvantage is poor residents' participation in the process.

"This time, we have set a target of reaching at least five lakh people in Chennai," says a member with the IEC team.

Animators are reaching out to college students, anganwadi staff, teachers and bulk waste generators explaining the processes that go behind this ranking and requesting them to take part in the exercise.

Two of the city's main waste management companies, Urbaser Sumeet and Ramky, are also help-

ing out in this exercise by reaching out to communities they are working with.

Citizen Feedback 2026 requires residents to answer 13 simple questions related to sanitation, waste collection, public toilets and the performance of local authorities. One has to complete the survey on their own as an OTP is generated for every submitted feedback.

Posts on its social media handles are expected to start coming once election results are out, nudging citizens to take part, says the staff.



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## Field surveys under way in states and UTs

The exercise is expected to be completed by the end of May

BY A SPECIAL CORRESPONDENT

Field surveys for the 10th edition of Swachh Survekshan 2026 is under way in many states and union territories since April 25.

The annual exercise by the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs, Government of India, is much awaited as this is an important component of ranking cities on various parameters including sustainable sanitation and waste management.

A communication dated April

24, 2026 by Roopa Mishra, Joint Secretary and Mission Director, Swachh Bharat Mission - Urban, outlines that the number of documents required for the "Service Level Progress" component has been reduced this time to ease the burden on Urban Local Bodies (ULBs).

The assessment teams visiting various ULBs to audit work done on the ground are expected to complete their field survey by May 31, says the communication. ULB officials are required to maintain operational records in

the form of logbooks. The communication also reiterates that citizen feedback, an important component in the ranking, is voluntary and unbiased, and cities should not mobilise pre-selected groups to interact with assessors.

In order to make Swachh Survekshan more inclusive, this time MoHUA has mandated that assessors deployed for on-ground surveys be fluent in the regional language and conduct the survey in the respective language, particularly in areas where English or Hindi is not preferred.

All questions in the assessment application pertaining to Direct Observation, Citizen Validation, and Citizen Feedback will be made available in the regional language to facilitate ease of understanding and response by citizens and ULB officials.

The Swachh Survekshan was launched on December, 20, 2025, followed by sharing the toolkit and ULB trainings.

The window to update Management Information System and City Profile data for all ULBs closed on April 10, 2026.



# An everyday utility created with metal discards

Integrating rice mill and automobile scrap material, a resident of Manimangalam panchayat creates a garbage unit that combines functionality, aesthetics and nostalgia



A view of the installation at Gurukul Street in Manimangalam; during Mattu Pongal the installation is decorated.

PHOTOS: PRINCE FREDERICK AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



PRINCE FREDERICK

Experiences in late childhood and early adulthood stick fast and long like cyanoacrylate, and would sometimes go on to be fodder for creativity. That is plain, observed logic. But if you are a pedant given to swallowing something only if it arrives with a saccharine coating of high-sounding concepts, here they are for you.

‘Schema Theory’ and ‘Reminiscence Bump’, both from psychology, explain this form of creativity. A 38-year-old architect displaying no signs of pedantry, M. Dilli Babu explains his *creation artistique* as

plainly as possible in any human language. “What I saw as a child I have recreated.”

What did he see?

Garbage being picked by carts drawn by oxen. At panchayats in distinctly rural settings, around three decades ago, one could expect garbage being gathered in a cart pulled by an ox. Manimangalam now might be in the peri-urban bracket, but is still a village panchayat in administrative terms, and back when Dilli Babu was a child, draft animals, precisely oxen, would have been on the conservancy team.

And what did he recreate?

A functional garbage cart paired

to an ox, the whole shebang created with upcycled materials. The installation is plonked at the entrance of Gurukul Street in Manimangalam, where Dilli Babu also has his house. Garbage is dumped and cleared. The installation is a head turner, something this writer can vouch for from personal experience, having stopped to take a long look at it while on the way to somewhere else.

Six years ago, when he got started on this project, Dilli Babu sought permission from the Manimangalam panchayat to repurpose a cart lying at the panchayat office unused and in a state of oblivion.

Chewed away, the garbage col-

lection unit had to have sheets welded into it, wheels replaced. The cart was paired with a bull, and the exercise drew upon a slew of material from the rice-grinding equipment that were past their usefulness in the rice mill.

Dilli Babu’s brother runs a rice mill, which made discarded materials from there the automatic choice for the sustainability project. Running a construction company named DB Architect, Dilli Babu could repurpose old construction material. Bent TMT rods define the contours of the ox. Motorcycle and cycle parts are unmistakable, despite being seamlessly blended into the *objet d’art* with efficient welding and painting. Suspension parts from a Tata 407 truck have also made a handsome contribution to the design.

Dilli Babu points out the rear section can be removed, facilitating easy garbage clearance. The cart can be lifted in a manner comparable to how a traditional cart can be

lifted and kept lifted after unharnessing the ox.

The garbage cart had a two-in-one functionality thrust into it with a 200-litre water tank being placed in the “innards” of the ox. The water could be accessed through a tap. The practice of filling the tank and offering it as an additional utility was discontinued when visitors from a Tasmac outlet nearby make the site of the garbage cart a pit stop, thanks to the availability of drinking water, says Dilli Babu.

With an explicit bovine connection, the installation is swept into Mattu Pongal celebrations every year. Prior to the event, it is not just bedecked with glitzy decorative items, but also put through a wringer of maintenance work and repairs.

The installation would have been fuelled by nostalgia, but it is nostalgia that scratches below the surface of feel-good sensation to surface something of immense everyday utilitarian value.





## Serving strangers in Velachery

**A**t AGS Colony in Velachery the residents are coming together to care for those on the streets. For over eight years, a daily buttermilk distribution near Hindu Vidyalaya has been serving conservancy workers, delivery staff, passengers and MTC bus crews during hours when the mercury shoots up.

Between 10 a.m. and 11:30 a.m. every day, nearly 70 litres of buttermilk is distributed, reaching around 250 to 300 people. The effort is sustained entirely through local participation. "Participation is by the entire community," says Upendra Sai, District President, Chennai South East. "Some residents bring curd, some bring water and many come forward to serve." Children are at the heart of the initiative. "This is primarily done by Balavikas children aged 6 to 15. The idea is to inculcate

## An everyday thing in Semmancherry

At the gated community Navin's Marisdale in Semmancherry, care for essential workers is not limited to peak summer, but built into its everyday functioning.

"Our Association takes great pride in fostering a warm, supportive, and inclusive environment," says secretary Muruganantham. One of the more distinctive efforts involves recycling: scrap collected from residents is sold, and the money is "reinvested with care" into staff welfare—covering tea, coffee, buttermilk during summer and



even occasional treats like biriyani. The support extends to what the campus itself produces. "Coconut, guava, pomegranate and banana are shared with our staff," he says,

## The COOL crew

As temperatures rise across Chennai, resident welfare associations in several neighbourhoods are stepping up summer relief efforts for conservancy workers, delivery personnel and other essential staff through drinking water kiosks and buttermilk distribution

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

the value of service in them," he explains, with adults supporting the preparation. The impact is visible in small but telling ways—buses pause briefly so passengers can have a drink, and nearby institutions extend support. Contributions are pooled in kind. "No single person is funding it. Each interested person contributes whatever they can," Sai adds.

referring to security guards, gardeners and sanitation workers. Any surplus is sold, with proceeds again routed back into welfare.

With summer intensifying, practical steps have been added. "Water is essential—unlimited drinking water is always accessible," he notes. Staff and the sanitation workers are also offered watermelon and tender coconut during the season. Importantly, work hours are adjusted: "They can come early and leave before the scorching heat."

"Coming from middle-class backgrounds ourselves, we understand their needs," Muruganantham adds. "Even small gestures can bring genuine happiness."

## The mud pot: a symbol of care in Mandaveli



**I**n Mandaveli, on Raja Street, next to the local PHC, residents have placed a mud pot filled with drinking water outside their apartment. It is accessible throughout the day to delivery agents, vendors, conservancy workers and visitors waiting at the clinic. Between 11:45 a.m. and 12:30 p.m., residents also distribute buttermilk, rose milk or nan-nari sharbat. The initiative, which began in April, will continue through May or until the summer loses its edge. Around 25 people benefit daily during this window. "We started this keeping the summer heat in mind. Many of them

are out on the streets for long hours," says Ganga Sridhar of the Mandaveli Raja Street Residents Welfare Association. "Now, some even time their rounds to stop here. That shows it's useful."

The effort is supported by a small group of resident donors and coordinated by apartment members and watchmen. On May 1, the association marked Labour Day with a one-day meal distribution for over 50 workers, including domestic helpers, vendors, and security staff. "It is a way of acknowledging the people who keep our daily lives running," a resident says.

## An 'oasis' in Perungalathur



**A**t SSM Nagar in Perungalathur, now in its fourth year, the initiative began with a simple observation: construction workers, delivery personnel, and daily wage labourers often had to buy drinking water or go without it.

"We found people buying water or asking for it during summer, and felt, as an association, we could start keeping water here," recalls Saravanan Kuppuswamy, former Secretary of SSMNFOA.

From a single water kiosk, the initiative has grown into a network of three strategically placed points across the neighbourhood. Each is replenished daily by a dedicated vendor, with association members and volunteers closely monitoring both quantity and quality. "Every day, the pots are filled. If it gets over, we ensure it is replenished immediately," he says.

The programme has since expanded to include evening buttermilk distribution, supported by Akshayakalpa. Between 4 p.m. and 5.30 p.m., dozens of people gather, from children returning from play to workers on their way home. "It is not about numbers but it is about making sure anyone who is thirsty is taken care of," he adds.



# A union of 'thermoset plastic' hearts

Close to 100 kilos of non-recyclable plastic waste was used to design two hearts that formed the backdrop of the stage where this wedding reception unfolded

LIFFY THOMAS

Stage decorations can vet someone's appetite for selfies. Desika Prabakar and Aravind Prasad, who got married on April 23, 2026, made sure the stage at their wedding reception provided a selfie opp as well as food for thought, some green thought.

At their wedding reception on April 26 at Alumni Club of Anna University, the couple got the decor for the stage done using 100 kilos of non-recyclable plastic waste. They called the celebration 'Wedding with Purpose'.

Two golden hearts largely defined the backdrop. They were made of thermoset plastics.

Desika, who took the green shots for this initiative, says ther-

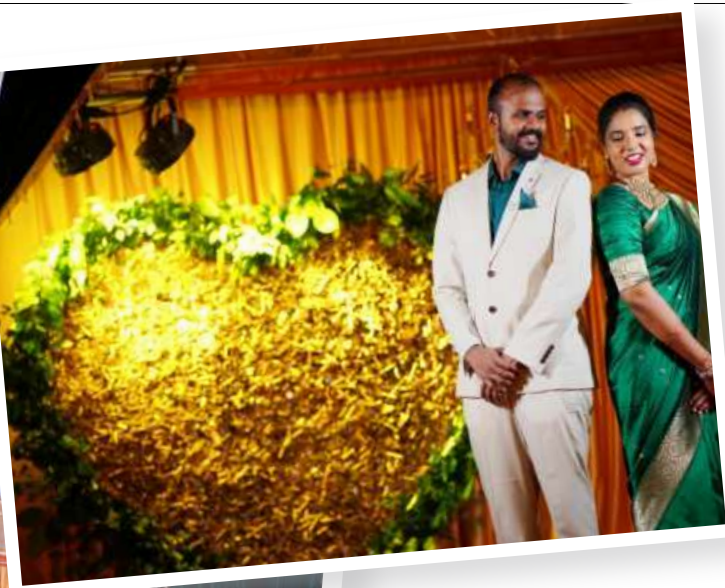
moset plastics are mainly used in automotive industries, and is a one-time use, after which it is often disposed of by burning at designated government facilities.

"We work with MSMEs and they have often brought up the challenge involved in disposing of such non-recyclable plastics with us. By giving them a proof of concept, we have shown a solution that can be replicated," says Desika, founder and director of DPur-

pose Foundation, a Section 8 non-profit supporting innovators in sustainability.

Currently there is no alternative recycling solutions for thermoset plastics and the couple decided to use the scrap as a piece of art.

"By making something creative out of it, we are allowing it to stay for some more years till an alternative is found," says Desika, a re-



Desika Prabakar and Aravind Prasad with the decor in the backdrop



guests to read and understand the message in the decor.

"I am sure people learnt something new from our Wedding with Purpose. The plan is to propose this for other shapes and occasions, replacing the need for additional plastics and giving waste a meaningful second life," she says.

Leo Impex and kvmG moulding Solutions are among others who helped with this initiative.

Many guests at the reception expressed interest in adopting similar sustainable concepts for their family events.

The two golden hearts will continue to be used as décor at future events by the event management firm to further spread awareness and inspire sustainable event practices, they say.

## Dance school celebrates 25th year



Kunjithapadha Natya Mandir, a Bharatanatyam dance school, celebrated its 25th anniversary at the TAG Auditorium, Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, Kilpauk, recently.

According to press release, the school, under the leadership of "Natya Peroli" "Nrithya Shiromani" Bhavani

Thyagarajan, presented a Bharatanatyam performance titled "Devi Trayam Devo."

Prominent personalities including textile industrialist Nalli Kuppusami Chetti and Carnatic musician K. P. S. Chinnaiah Sivakumar graced the occasion as chief guests, adds the release.

## Chennai Super Mom on May 10

The 13th edition of Chennai Super Mom will be held on May 10 at Ampa Skyone Aminjikarai; 3 p.m. onwards.

Organised by IRIS Events, this year a special segment will feature moms who are above 50 and their inspiring journeys.

Other highlights include 'Parambarya Samayal', a fun cooking contest

where moms create innovative snacks and present them with a unique slogan; and 'Mom & Me', a bonding segment with mother-child fashion walk, fitness activities, and a parenting debate.

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During the awards ceremony; and (below) a view of the campus.

## School bags award for environmental action

**C**hettinad-Sarvalokaa Education International School, located within the ecologically rich 108-acre Chettinad Health City in OMR, Kelambakkam, has been recognised by Earthday.org for its commitment to sustainability practices, a milestone that reflects years of deeply rooted environmental action woven into the school's very identity.

According to a press release, founded in 2017 as a Cambridge International School offering both day and residential facilities, Sarvalokaa has long believed that education and environmental stewardship belong together.

The school operates within a Net-

Zero, All-Electric, closed-loop campus, generating 51% of its energy through solar and wind, treating and reusing 83% of its daily wastewater, maintaining zero groundwater dependency, and absorbing up to 60 tonnes of CO<sub>2</sub> annually through its dense native forest cover spanning 5.8 acres of native flora and a thriving three-acre mango forest.

The press release adds that the campus is entirely free of motor vehicles, operating instead through walking and cycling pathways that create a silent, clean, and healing environment for learners. A zero-waste circular ecosystem, supported by seven composting units and a strict no-plastic policy, en-

sures that the school's ecological footprint remains minimal.

But beyond infrastructure, it is the children who make this recognition truly meaningful.

From growing food seed-to-plate and caring for animals to building bug hotels, creating natural rangoli, and learning barefoot amidst nature, Sarvalokaa's learners live it every single day. The school's nature-inspired curriculum transforms the campus itself into a living classroom.

This Earthday.org recognition joins a growing list of acknowledgements for Sarvalokaa, the release adds.

For more information, visit [www.sarvalokaa.org](http://www.sarvalokaa.org)



## Swetha Anand elected as president of CREGU India



The India chapter of Centro Di Ricerca Sull'Educazione Dei Giovani Per L'UNESCO (CREGU), a centre based in Italy dedicated to advancing youth education and research, has inducted Swetha Sundeeep Anand as its national president for UNESCO Youth Education Research Center in India.

The induction ceremony

was held at Bharath Institute of Science and Technology in Tambaram.

The induction ceremony was officiated by Melisa Aysegil Gal, head of the Secretariat of CREGU, who was the chief guest.

Melisa Aysegil Gal delivered a keynote address on 'Youth Voices on Sustainable Development Goals'.

## Varsity wins honours

Saveetha Institute of Medical and Technical Sciences has secured first place among India's best private universities in the Times Higher Education Asian University Rankings 2026. The varsity has ranked 128th out of 929 universities from 36 countries based on key criteria such as teaching, research environment, research quality, industry, and international outlook, according to a press release.

N. M. Veeraiyan, chancellor of the varsity, expressed pride in the achievement, stating that this recognition reflects the institution's unwavering dedication to quality education, impactful research, and societal contribution.

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